CHAPTER 12

LANCASHIRE

2002

It's my first delivery ever as a professional cricketer, for Lancashire's second XI. We are playing Surrey's second team at Stanley Park, Blackpool. I run in and, as I do, my legs become unstable. Halfway through the stride, I become unfamiliar with what bowling even is; nerves have rendered me an empty shell. As I get to the crease, it feels as though I'm attempting an impression of a bowler. I jump at the crease. I've never tried to jump at the crease before. I am, somehow, as if trying to rewind time, jumping backwards, ball still in hand. As I land, my back foot takes out both the leg and middle stump and I fall in a heap. Before I even dare look up, the umpire, Ian Gould, is talking to me. 'What the hell was that, son?' he asks.

This is the cost of the sequence of events since the breaking of the bat in Burnley; things have happened really quickly, mostly good and sometimes bad. It's like driving a fast car I have no control of. I've been starting to consistently scare older men, county pros, bowling quickly without really thinking about it. It's like all the years of wishing and trying have stored up and exploded inside me. I've been handed a trial and, despite falling into the stumps occasionally and going through periods of bowling with a radar that is set to spin, I have been successful and landed in a Lancashire squad with a whole host of street-smart, wise, older international cricketers: Peter Martin, Neil Fairbrother, Glen Chapple, Mike Watkinson, Warren Hegg, Mike Atherton and Ian Austin. They are all Lancastrian and have a kind of inbuilt community spirit in bringing through other Lancastrian cricketers. I am one. The ball is going everywhere when I bowl it, sometimes bowling